The difference between an oral performance by a poet-entertainer and a functionary carrying out the orders of the ruler would have lain mainly in the content—a political rather than literary agenda—with the manner of the address being perhaps similar, if more declamatory and officious in tone.

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What did Ashoka want to convey in his very first rock edict? This earliest communication has survived in the very form in which it was put down in the third century BCE at Rupnath, and a full English translation of it gives a good idea of how the emperor set about the business for which he is best known. Other versions of this message will figure subsequently, but the Rupnath edict gives a good sense of what Ashoka thought worthy of recounting and communicating to his subjects: not matters of state, but the state of his mind. He has become a Buddhist. His metamorphosis needs to be understood and emulated. So it is the process and the consequences of his conversion that he highlights.

Devanampiya speaks thus.

Two and a half years and somewhat more (have passed) since I am openly a Shakya.

But (I had) not been very zealous.

But a year and somewhat more (has passed) since I have visited the Samgha and have been very zealous.

Those gods who during that time had been unmingled (with men) in Jambudvipa, have now been made (by me) mingled (with them).

For this is the fruit of zeal.

And this cannot be reached by (persons) of high rank (alone), (but) even a lowly (person) is able to attain even the great heaven if he is zealous.

And for the following purpose has (this) proclamation been issued, (that) both the lowly and the exalted may be zealous, and (that) even (my) borderers may know (it), (and) that this same zeal may be of long duration.